

SULU-SULAWESI SEAS

The world's most biodiverse marine ecoregion

The Sulu-Sulawesi marine ecoregion covers around 660,000 sq miles (900,000 sq km) of the Sulu and Sulawesi seas and the inland seas of the Philippines. It sits at the top of the Coral Triangle of Southeast Asia. Its complex mix of marine habitats includes seagrass plains, coral reefs, deep sea trenches, seamounts, active volcanic islands, and mangrove forests. The diverse habitats support astonishing underwater biodiversity with more than 2,000 species of marine fish and 400 species of coral represented. The seas are also home to five of the world's seven sea turtle species, and the dugong and Irrawaddy dolphin—both vulnerable marine mammals.

Threatened paradise

The water is predominantly warm and clear thanks to the tropical climate. Such bountiful and beautiful waters draw crowds of tourists that come to experience the coral

reefs and islands. Many of the reefs are popular dive sites, and the Tubbata Reefs in the Sulu Sea were declared UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1993. Fishermen exploit the large populations of commercial fish, such as tuna.

Tourism and growing local populations put pressure on the marine environment through the development of coastlines and the use of coral for building. There is also increased pollution from untreated sewage and industrial and agricultural runoff into the sea. Efforts are being made by conservationists to curb harmful fishing techniques that use dynamite or cyanide, which damage the coral reefs and kill marine life indiscriminately.



OVERFISHING
Along with commercial fishing for the international food market, local people catch fish for their own consumption, and coral reef fish are sought for the aquarium trade. The sardine population is approaching collapse.

LIVING FOSSIL
Discovered in 1997, the Sulawesi coelacanth is one of two survivors of a group of fish that was thought to be extinct. It has become a flagship species for the better management and protection of the Bunaken National Park where it is found.

COELACANTH
Five species of

Home to around 2,000 species of fish

More than 400 species of coral

TOXIC SEA SLUG
The colorful Loch's chromodoris is a sea slug that lives on coral reefs. It feeds on sponges and is able to ingest their toxins into its own body, making it inedible to potential predators. Its bright coloration serves as a warning that it is poisonous.